Kindergarten Water Safety Classroom Package

Three dry-land lessons for children about ages 5 to 6: spot water places, ask first, know what keeps you safe, and get a grown-up.

At a glance

AGES
About 5 to 6 (kindergarten). Use your judgment; children develop at different rates.

LESSONS
3 lessons, about 15 to 20 minutes each

GROUP SIZE
Whole class, small groups of 4 to 6, or partners

WATER NEEDED
None. Every activity is done on dry land, with no pool, tub or water.

Children learn to spot water places at home, at school and outside; to ask first; that toys don't keep them safe in water; and what to do if something goes wrong: **stop, stay back and get a grown-up.**

What this package does not do. It does not teach swimming, and it does not make any child safe around water on their own. Kindergartners are never asked to help someone in the water: no reaching, no throwing, no going in. Their job is to get a grown-up. Keeping children safe near water is always an adult's job: close supervision, barriers around pools and, for open water, life jackets. Your school's and district's policies come first.

How to use it

- **Whole class.** Each lesson fits a 15 to 20 minute block at morning meeting, health or a read-aloud time. The activity sheets can be a follow-up center.
- **Small groups and partners.** The sorting game and the help-words practice work well with partners or groups of 4 to 6, with an adult nearby.
- **Order and pace.** Teach the lessons in order over one or two weeks.
- **Repeat it.** Revisit the "Stop, stay back, get a grown-up" practice before field days, field trips, warm weather and summer break.
- **Send it home.** Send the family note (Printable F) home after Lesson 3, with the "My safe grown-ups" sheet.

Learning goals

By the end of the three lessons, most children will be able to:

1. Name at least three water places at home, at school or outside, including small ones like a bathtub or a bucket, and explain that a grown-up needs to be watching.
2. Ask a grown-up before going near water, and wait for an answer.
3. Tell toys (swim rings, noodles, floaties) apart from safety gear (a life jacket), and say that a grown-up watching still matters.
4. Say or show what to do if someone in the water needs help or a friend is missing near water: stop, stay back, shout for a grown-up and point.
5. Name two safe grown-ups, such as one at school and one at home or another place they spend time.

Where these goals come from. WaterWiseKids wrote these learning goals, the classroom phrases and the activities for this package. They put national safety guidance into words children can practice. They are not quotes from the organizations cited below, and the package is not aligned to or endorsed by any standards body or organization.

Safety notes for teachers

Read these before you teach. They are the cited facts behind the lessons.

- **Why this age.** For children ages 5 to 14, the CDC reports that drowning is the second leading cause of unintentional injury death after motor vehicle crashes (CDC, Drowning Facts).
- **Adults watch, closely and constantly.** The CDC advises designating a responsible adult to supervise closely and constantly when children are in or near water, including bathtubs. It also notes that drowning happens in seconds and is often silent, and that children who have had swimming lessons still need close and constant supervision (CDC, Preventing Drowning).
- **"Ask first" comes from the Red Cross.** The American Red Cross advises teaching children to always ask permission to go near water (American Red Cross, Water Safety).
- **Toys are not safety gear.** The CDC says not to rely on air-filled or foam toys, "as these are not safety devices" (CDC). The AAP says floaties, water wings and inflatable toys "do not prevent drowning" (AAP, HealthyChildren.org).
- **Life jackets.** The AAP says children should always wear life jackets when in, on or near natural bodies of water, such as lakes or rivers (AAP). The CDC says life jackets reduce the risk of drowning while boating for people of all ages and swimming abilities (CDC).
- **Swim lessons help, and supervision still matters.** The CDC says formal swimming lessons can reduce the risk of drowning (CDC), and the AAP notes that swim lessons don't make kids "drown proof" (AAP, Swim Lessons).

Rules for teaching this package

- Use no real water. The "pretend pool" is blue paper, a blue blanket or tape on a dry floor.
- No child plays a person "in the water," and no child lies down in or near the pretend pool. Use a puppet or stuffed animal for stories.
- Do not teach kindergartners to reach, throw things or go into water to help anyone. Their job is to stop, stay back and get a grown-up. Grown-ups decide what happens next, including calling 911.
- Keep the tone calm and matter-of-fact. The goal is a habit, not fear.
- If a child shares a frightening water experience or a loss, listen calmly, don't press for details, and follow your school's procedures for letting families and the counselor or nurse know.

Teacher preparation checklist

- [ ] Read the whole package, including the safety notes.
- [ ] Check your school's and district's policies on safety lessons and on what to share with families.
- [ ] Print the picture cards (Printable A) and the place cards (Printable B), one set per group, and cut them apart.
- [ ] Print Printables C, D and E, one per child, and the family note (Printable F), one per family.
- [ ] Make the pretend pool from blue paper, a blue blanket or painter's tape on the floor. Keep it dry.
- [ ] Pick a quiet alternative to shouting (for example, waving both arms or holding up the "Get a grown-up" card).
- [ ] Ask families how they say "stop," "water" and "help" at home, and practice those words.
- [ ] Check each child's IEP or 504 plan and plan the adaptations you will use.
- [ ] Decide which staff member will check in with a child who finds the topic upsetting.
- [ ] Optional: a puppet or stuffed animal for Lesson 3.

Materials

Everything is paper or classroom basics. None of it uses water.

- Printable A: seven picture cards (Stop, Stay back, Ask first, Get a grown-up, A grown-up is watching, Life jacket, Toys are not safety gear)
- Printable B: nine place cards (six water places, three dry places)
- Printable C: "Spot the water places" activity sheet, one per child
- Printable D: "Safety gear or just a toy?" activity sheet, one per child

- Printable E: "My safe grown-ups and help words" sheet, one per child
- Printable F: family take-home note, one per family
- A pretend pool: blue paper, a blue blanket or painter's tape (dry)
- Two sorting spots on the floor or a pocket chart, one with a hand-written "Dry" label; crayons or pencils; optional puppet or stuffed animal

The three lessons

The "Say" boxes are suggested words. Use your own voice.

Lesson 1: Water is everywhere 15 to 20 min

Goal: children name water places, including small ones, and explain that a grown-up needs to be watching.
You need: Printable A ("A grown-up is watching" card), Printable B place cards, two sorting spots, Printable C.

1. **Wonder (3 min).**

   > **Say:** Where do you see water at home? At school? Outside?

   Collect answers. If no one names them, add a bathtub, a bucket, a sink, a puddle, a pool, a pond and the beach.

2. **Sort (5 min).** Put the "A grown-up is watching" card on one spot and a "Dry" label on the other. Children take turns sorting the place cards.

   > **Say:** Is there water here? If there is, a grown-up needs to be watching. Put it with the grown-up card.

   Ask about the bucket and the bathtub: "Is that a lot of water or a little? Does a little water still need a grown-up?" (Yes.)

3. **The water watcher (3 min).**

   > **Say:** When kids are near water, one grown-up has a special job: watching the water. That grown-up keeps their eyes on the kids, not on a phone. Who could be a water watcher for you?

4. **Activity sheet (5 to 8 min).** Children complete Printable C: circle every place that has water.

5. **Close (1 min).**

   > **Say:** Water places need a grown-up watching. Even a little water. Even a bucket.

Check for understanding: the child names three water places and says who needs to be watching.
Repeat: "I spy a water place" on a walk around the school or in picture books.

Lesson 2: Ask first, and what keeps you safe 15 to 20 min

Goal: children ask before going near water, and tell toys apart from safety gear.
You need: the Ask first, A grown-up is watching, Life jacket and Toys are not safety gear cards; the dry pretend pool; Printable D.

1. **Ask first (6 min).** Show the Ask first card.

   > **Say:** Before you go near water, you always ask a grown-up first. Then you wait for the answer.

   Partners take turns at the edge of the pretend pool. One child is the grown-up; the other stops at the tape line and asks:

   > **Children say:** May I go near the water?

   The "grown-up" answers either "Not now" or "Yes, I'll come and watch you." Then switch. Praise children who stop at the line and wait, and remind everyone that near real water, only a real grown-up can say yes.

2. **Safety gear or just a toy? (6 min).** Show the Toys card and the Life jacket card.

   > **Say:** Swim rings, noodles and floaties are fun toys. But toys don't keep you safe in the water. This is a life jacket. A life jacket is safety gear. Kids wear one on boats and near lakes and rivers. And even with a life jacket, a grown-up still watches.

   Ask: "What keeps kids safe near water?" Guide to: a grown-up watching, asking first, and a life jacket on boats and near lakes and rivers.

3. **Swim lessons (2 min, optional).**

   > **Say:** Some of you take swim lessons, and some of you don't yet. Swimmers and non-swimmers all need a grown-up watching.

4. **Activity sheet (5 min).** Children complete Printable D: draw a line from each picture to "Keeps me safe" or "Just a toy."

Check for understanding: the child stops at the line, asks and waits; and sorts toys from safety gear.
Repeat: do the "May I?" practice at the classroom door before outdoor play on warm days.

Lesson 3: Get a grown-up 15 to 20 min

Goal: children say or show what to do if someone in the water needs help or a friend is missing near water, and name two safe grown-ups.
You need: the Stop, Stay back and Get a grown-up cards; the dry pretend pool; a puppet or stuffed animal (we call it Pip here); Printable E.

1. **Three steps (3 min).** Show the cards in order.

   > **Say:** If you see someone in the water who needs help, or you can't find a friend near water, you do three things: Stop. Stay back. Get a grown-up.

2. **Pip's story (4 min).** Use the puppet beside the pretend pool.

   > **Say:** Pip and a friend are at the park with their grown-ups. There is a pond at the park. Pip looks around. Where is Pip's friend? Pip can't find her! What should Pip do?

   Guide to: Pip stops, stays back from the water, and tells a grown-up right away, with a big voice and pointing. Then answer as the grown-up:

   > **Say:** Thank you for telling me right away, Pip. I'll take it from here. You stay with the other kids.

3. **Help words (4 min).**

   > **Say:** Grown-ups need to hear you. Use a big voice and point.

   > **Children say:** Help! Come quick! Someone needs help in the water!

   Practice in partners: one child points toward the pretend pool and says the help words; the partner pretends to be the grown-up and says, "I'm coming!" Children who prefer not to shout can wave both arms or hold up the "Get a grown-up" card.

4. **Why we don't go in (2 min).**

   > **Say:** Why don't we go in the water, or reach in, to help? Because you could fall in too. Helping in the water is a grown-up job. Your job is to get a grown-up fast.

5. **Activity sheet (5 min).** Children complete Printable E: draw or write two safe grown-ups and their help words.

Check for understanding: the child says or shows stop, stay back, shout and point, and names two safe grown-ups.
Repeat: retell Pip's story with new places (the beach, a pond at the park, the bathtub at home) every few weeks.

Adaptations

Follow each child's IEP or 504 plan and the advice of their specialists first. These ideas fit most classrooms.

Emerging language and early readers

- Pair every phrase with its picture card. Accept pointing, a gesture, a sign or a short phrase as a full answer.
- On the activity sheets, children can draw instead of write, or dictate to an adult.
- Use families' words for "stop," "water" and "help" alongside English, and let children practice the help words in either language.
- Pre-teach the words "water watcher," "life jacket" and "safety gear" with the cards before the lesson.

Sensory needs

- Tell children before any loud practice. Offer a quiet way to get a grown-up: waving both arms, holding up the card, or a sign.
- Let children sit at the edge of the group, wear headphones or hold a fidget.

Mobility needs

- Do the "May I?" practice seated, with the tape line placed where every child can reach it.
- For the activity sheets, children can point, use a stamp, or use larger crayons and enlarged copies.

Attention

- Split any lesson into two shorter parts on different days, and keep the same words every time.

Observation checklist

Watch during the lessons and repeats. Mark ✓ on their own, **H** with help, or **–** not yet.

Child	Names 3 water places	Asks first and waits	Sorts toys from safety gear	Stop, stay back, shout and point	Names 2 safe grown-ups

Child	Names 3 water places	Asks first and waits	Sorts toys from safety gear	Stop, stay back, shout and point	Names 2 safe grown-ups

Keep completed checklists with your confidential class records; don't post or share them. This checklist records classroom practice only. It does not measure whether a child is safe around real water, and it is not a swimming or water competency assessment.

Printables and family note

Open a sheet PDF for one handout, or the printable sheets PDF at the top of the page for the complete set. Free to print and copy for classroom and family use.

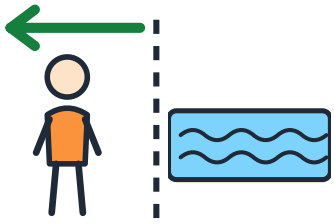
A. Picture cards

Cut apart. Use one set per group.



Stop

Hand out flat like a stop sign



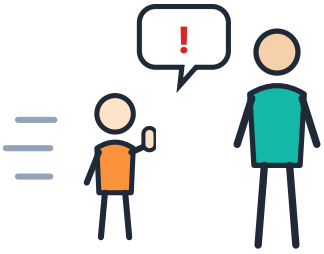
Stay back

Take a big step back



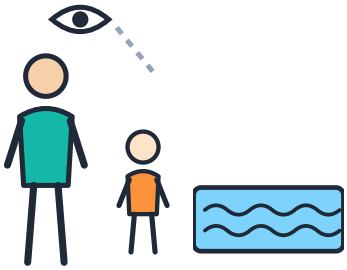
Ask first

May I go near the water?



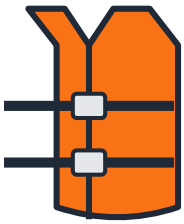
Get a grown-up

Shout and point



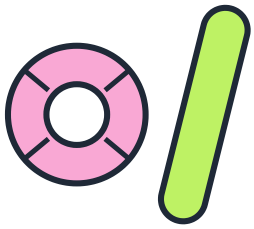
A grown-up is watching

Water places need a grown-up



Life jacket

Safety gear for boats, lakes and rivers

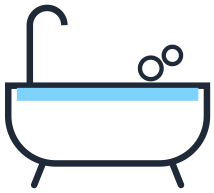


Toys are not safety gear

Swim rings, noodles and floaties are for fun

B. Water places and dry places

Cut apart for the Lesson 1 sort.



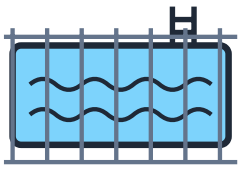
Bathtub



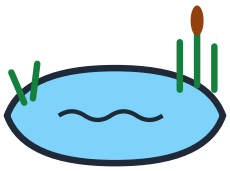
Bucket



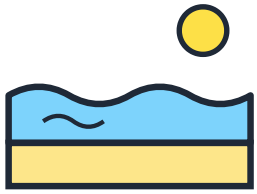
Wading pool



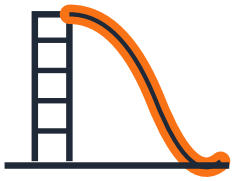
Pool



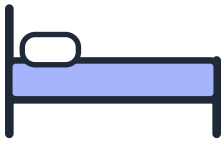
Pond



Beach



Slide



Bed



Blocks

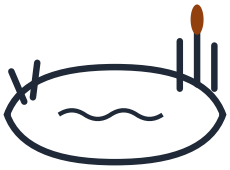
C. Spot the water places

Name:

Circle every place that has water. Then color them. A grown-up needs to be watching at every water place.



Books



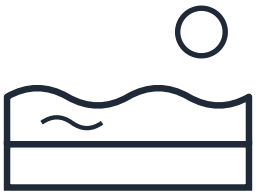
Pond



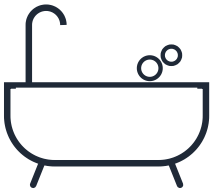
Bucket



Bed



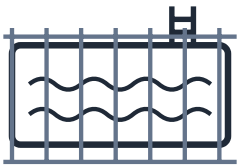
Beach



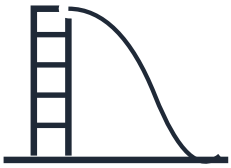
Bathtub



Blocks



Pool

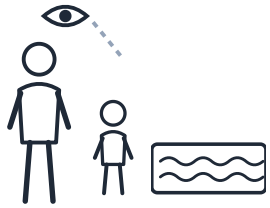


Slide

D. Safety gear or just a toy?

Name: _____

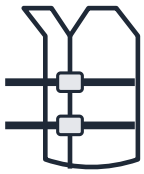
Draw a line from each picture to "Keeps me safe" or "Just a toy."



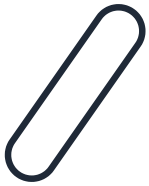
A grown-up watching



Swim ring



Life jacket



Pool noodle

Keeps me safe

Just a toy

Answers for teachers: a grown-up watching and a life jacket keep kids safe; the swim ring and the noodle are toys (CDC, AAP). Even with a life jacket, a grown-up still watches. WaterWiseKids Kindergarten Water Safety Package, version 1.0.

E. My safe grown-ups and help words

Name: _____

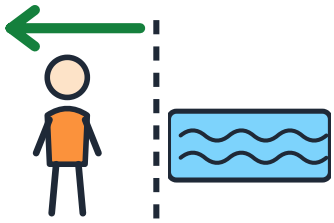
Draw or write a safe grown-up at school and one at home or another place you spend time.

At school	At home or another place

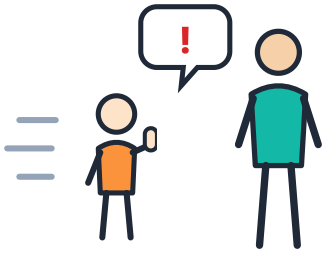
If someone in the water needs help, or I can't find my friend, I:



Stop



Stay back



Get a grown-up

My help words:

HELP! COME QUICK!

F. Family note: what we learned about water safety

Dear families,

Our class just finished three water safety lessons. Your child practiced:

- **Water places need a grown-up watching**, even a bathtub or a bucket.
- **Ask first** before going near any water, and wait for an answer.
- **Toys don't keep you safe.** Swim rings, noodles and floaties are toys. A life jacket is safety gear for boats, lakes and rivers.
- **If something is wrong: stop, stay back, and get a grown-up.** Children never go in or reach in to help. Ask your child to show you the help words!

What grown-ups can do, from national health and safety organizations:

- Watch closely and constantly whenever your child is in or near water, including the bathtub. Drowning happens in seconds and is often silent (CDC).
- Floaties, water wings and inflatable toys do not prevent drowning (AAP). Children should always wear a life jacket in, on or near lakes and rivers (AAP).
- A home pool needs a fence at least 4 feet high on all four sides, with a self-closing, self-latching gate (CDC, AAP).
- Swim lessons can help reduce drowning risk, and children who have had lessons still need close, constant supervision (CDC, AAP).
- Learn CPR. CPR skills could save someone's life in the time it takes for paramedics to arrive (CDC).

These lessons did not teach swimming, and they do not make any child safe near water alone. A grown-up watching is what keeps children safe.

Teacher: _____ **Class:** _____

Sources: CDC Preventing Drowning (cdc.gov/drowning/prevention); AAP HealthyChildren.org, Drowning Prevention for Curious Toddlers and Swim Lessons. Checked October 12, 2026. From the WaterWiseKids Kindergarten Water Safety Package, version 1.0, waterwisekids.com/educators/

Sources

Each statement credited to an organization links to that source; other suggestions are WaterWiseKids's own. Sources were checked on October 12, 2026. WaterWiseKids is not affiliated with or endorsed by these organizations.

- CDC, Drowning Facts (page dated January 27, 2026; checked October 12, 2026). www.cdc.gov (https://www.cdc.gov/drowning/data-research/facts/index.html)

- CDC, Preventing Drowning (page dated September 29, 2025; checked October 12, 2026). www.cdc.gov (https://www.cdc.gov/drowning/prevention/index.html)
- American Red Cross, Water Safety (no date shown; checked October 12, 2026). www.redcross.org (https://www.redcross.org/get-help/how-to-prepare-for-emergencies/types-of-emergencies/water-safety.html)
- American Academy of Pediatrics, HealthyChildren.org: Drowning Prevention for Curious Toddlers: What Parents Need to Know (updated May 18, 2026; checked October 12, 2026). www.healthychildren.org (https://www.healthychildren.org/English/safety-prevention/at-play/Pages/Water-Safety-and-Young-Children.aspx)
- American Academy of Pediatrics, HealthyChildren.org: Swim Lessons for Children: When to Start & What to Consider (updated May 18, 2026; checked October 12, 2026). www.healthychildren.org (https://www.healthychildren.org/English/safety-prevention/at-play/Pages/Swim-Lessons.aspx)